MDQ PREDICTION: Iran–US/Israel Conflict: Pathways to Lasting Peace

Scenario ID: iran-us-israel-peace-2026 | Analysis Date: 2026-04-03

> **Prediction Ask:** By 2030, what is the most viable pathway to a negotiated, lasting peace between Iran and the US/Israel axis that addresses: (1) Iran's nuclear program disposition, (2) security guarantees, (3) economic reintegration, and (4) regional stability — and what are the primary obstacles and success conditions for each?

—— EXECUTIVE PREDICTION ——

Most Likely Outcome (Confidence: 60–72%)

The most viable pathway to lasting peace between Iran and the US/Israel bloc is a **phased, China-brokered grand settlement** executed in two stages: a **ceasefire-plus-economic-reprieve** by late 2026, followed by a **comprehensive nuclear and security framework** by 2028–2029. This is not a triumphant diplomatic breakthrough — it is a survival-driven convergence, driven by Iran's economic collapse, global energy market pressure, and the mutual exhaustion of a war neither party can sustain indefinitely.

The foundational logic is straightforward: Iran's economy is in acute crisis (Strait of Hormuz closure, destroyed nuclear infrastructure, degraded military), yet Iran retains enough strategic leverage — the Strait, residual nuclear knowledge, proxy networks, and Chinese/Russian diplomatic backing — to demand a face-saving settlement rather than capitulate. The US, facing Strait-induced oil price shocks and Gulf state opposition to further escalation, has incentive to offer one. China, as Iran's primary economic patron and the Gulf's primary oil supplier, has overwhelming incentive to broker the deal and will likely do so.

Stage 1 (Q3–Q4 2026): Ceasefire + Humanitarian + Strait Opening
Iran partially reopens the Strait of Hormuz for non-US-flagged shipping in exchange for a pause in strikes and an initial tranche of frozen asset releases (~$20–30B). Negotiations proceed via Oman and Pakistan channels. No formal acknowledgment by either side that "talks" are occurring. Mojtaba Khamenei maintains maximalist rhetoric publicly while the Ghalibaf government conducts back-channel engagement.

Stage 2 (2027–2029): Comprehensive Framework ("JCPOA-2 Plus")
A nuclear agreement caps Iranian enrichment at 20% purity with IAEA monitoring re-established. In return: phased sanctions relief over 36 months, a US executive-level non-aggression statement co-signed by China and Russia, and Iran's re-entry into global oil markets at 2–3 million barrels per day. The IRGC accepts the deal in exchange for institutional survival guarantees and preservation of its domestic economic empire. China serves as economic guarantor of Iranian compliance.

What "Lasting Peace" Means in Practice
This is not a warm peace. It is a *durable managed hostility reduction* — closer to the 1953 Korean Armistice than the Oslo Accords. Iran and Israel will not normalize relations. Iran's nuclear "threshold" ambiguity will persist. Proxy networks will be formally frozen but not dismantled. KSA will secure separate bilateral gains from Iran (Yemen, Bahrain non-interference). The Strait remains technically controllable by Iran as a deterrent hedge.

Key Supporting Dynamics

1. China's Structural Leverage is the Decisive Variable (SH composite: 0.806)
No other actor simultaneously holds economic leverage over Iran (25-year strategic partnership, primary oil buyer) and credibility with Gulf states (KSA-Iran 2023 brokering precedent). China has already debuted its peace plan (April 1, 2026) and has positioned itself explicitly as the "honest broker" alternative to US unilateralism. Beijing's own energy security depends on Strait re-opening. This is not geopolitical altruism — it is structural interest alignment. China's mediation is the most certain element of any viable pathway.

2. Economic Survival Overrides Ideology — for Both Sides (SH composites: 0.752–0.792)

Iran's Strait of Hormuz closure damages Iran's own future economy (no oil exports, no reconstruction imports) as much as it damages global markets. The Iranian public's "rally-round-flag" effect (historically 6–18 months post-conflict) will erode rapidly given pre-existing economic exhaustion from sanctions. Simultaneously, Trump's domestic base will tolerate a "deal" framed as a "win" (nuclear surrender narrative) even if it involves significant concessions. Economic gravity will pull both parties toward negotiation faster than ideology would suggest.

3. IRGC Institutional Compliance is the Critical Constraint (SH composites: 0.638–0.692)

The single most important domestic variable is IRGC acceptance of any deal. The IRGC controls Iran's nuclear program, proxy networks, and effectively functions as a veto power over foreign policy. The IRGC will accept a deal only if: (a) the deal does not include formal prosecution of IRGC leaders for war crimes, (b) IRGC's domestic economic empire is explicitly preserved, and (c) some residual nuclear threshold capability (knowledge base, dispersed centrifuges) is maintained. Any deal that requires full IRGC capitulation will fail. Successful diplomacy must provide the IRGC an institutional off-ramp.

Largest Uncertainty & Wildcard

The Critical Unknown: Mojtaba Khamenei's Ideological Disposition

The new Supreme Leader (elected March 8, 2026) is the single most consequential unknown. If Mojtaba Khamenei pursues "resistant pragmatism" (following in the precedent of Khomeini's 1988 "cup of poison" ceasefire acceptance), the pathway above is viable. If he calculates that demonstrating hardline credentials is necessary to establish legitimacy among IRGC hardliners — refusing any deal perceived as surrender — the timeline extends by 18–24 months and the probability of a comprehensive settlement drops significantly.

Wildcard (Tail Risk, ~12% probability): Israeli Unilateral Strike During Negotiations

A unilateral Israeli strike on remaining Iranian nuclear infrastructure or military assets during active negotiations would collapse the peace process, trigger Iranian retaliation, and force the US into a binary choice between backing Israel and maintaining negotiations. Historical Israeli behavior (striking during diplomatic

windows — Osirak 1981, Syria 2007) makes this a credible, non-negligible risk. US must exercise significant pressure on Netanyahu to prevent this.

Confidence Assessment

Scenario	Probability	Timeframe
Phased China-brokered deal (JCPOA-2 Plus)	60–72%	2026–2029
Prolonged stalemate (no deal for 5+ years)	18–25%	2026–2031+
Iranian nuclear breakout / Cold Peace	8–12%	2027–2030
Full regime change in Iran (collapse/revolution)	5–8%	2027–2031

Justification: The 60–72% confidence reflects strong structural incentives for a deal (economic, energy, China leverage) offset by critical domestic political constraints (IRGC veto, new Supreme Leader legitimacy dynamics, US Congressional opposition to sanctions relief). The wide confidence band (12 percentage points) reflects genuine uncertainty around Mojtaba Khamenei's direction and IRGC compliance.

—— CATEGORY PREDICTIONS ——

CAT-01: Nuclear Disposition & Security Architecture

Category Prediction Confidence: MODERATE-HIGH (0.69)

The nuclear question is the foundational axis of any peace settlement — it was the US/Israel casus belli and remains Iran's most strategically valuable card. The post-strike nuclear landscape is genuinely ambiguous: US/Israeli strikes caused significant damage (Natanz, Fordow, Isfahan hit), but Iran pre-emptively moved 440kg of 60%-enriched uranium, its knowledge base survives, and key scientists dispersed. The CIA and DIA offer contradictory damage assessments (months vs. years setback), adding uncertainty.

Most Plausible Outcome (SCAT-01-01, composite 0.738): Iran accepts enrichment caps at 20% purity with IAEA monitoring re-established as part of a phased deal. This is not denuclearization — it is a JCPOA-style freeze with enhanced verification. Iran retains the knowledge, the dispersed centrifuge capacity, and the political commitment to re-activate if the deal collapses. The

nuclear program functions as a *negotiating asset* indefinitely, not a *weapons program* — and this is the durable equilibrium. Iran suspended IAEA cooperation as a leverage move (consistent with the 2019-2021 pattern of using IAEA access as negotiating chips), and will restore it as part of a settlement package.

Security Guarantees (SCAT-01-02, composite 0.692): Iran will receive written non-aggression assurances — not a Senate-ratified treaty (which is politically impossible in the current US Congress) but executive-level commitments co-signed by China and Russia, functioning as informal security guarantors. The Budapest Memorandum's failure (which left Ukraine without US protection) will make Iran extremely skeptical of paper guarantees; the key differentiator is China's economic stake in Iranian compliance, which creates a structural enforcement mechanism.

Regional WMD Architecture (SCAT-01-03, composite 0.715): Israel's nuclear ambiguity will not be addressed in any settlement — this is a red line for both the US and Israel. Iran will accept this asymmetry (as it has since 1979) in exchange for economic relief, but will periodically invoke the MNWFZ demand as a diplomatic pressure tool. The "regional nuclear free zone" remains a rhetorical aspiration, not a deliverable outcome within 2030.

Proxy/Conventional Military (SCAT-01-04, composite 0.714): The IRGC's proxy network (Hezbollah, Houthis, various Iraqi militias) is already significantly degraded from the 2024-2026 conflict period. Iran will accept a "cold freeze" on proxy expansion and escalation as part of a deal, framed domestically as "strategic patience" rather than capitulation. Formal proxy dismantlement is not achievable — these networks have their own organizational logic and will persist in reduced form regardless of Tehran's formal commitments.

Key Tension: The US and Israel want verifiable nuclear elimination; Iran will only accept verifiable limitation. This gap is bridgeable — JCPOA proved it — but requires both sides to accept the other's minimum: Iran must accept IAEA monitoring with "anytime, anywhere" inspection rights (stronger than JCPOA); the US must accept that Iran's nuclear knowledge cannot be erased and that threshold status is the durable endpoint.

CAT-02: Diplomatic Process & Negotiation Architecture

Category Prediction Confidence: HIGH (0.73)

This is the category where the structural pathway is clearest. The diplomatic infrastructure for US-Iran negotiations already exists and has been activated: Oman has established itself as the primary channel (most JCPOA-era negotiations ran through Muscat); Pakistan successfully transmitted the US 15-point ceasefire plan; Qatar has existing diplomatic relationships; and China has formally entered with its own peace plan (April 1, 2026).

Most Plausible Pathway (SCAT-02-01 + 02-02, composites 0.752 and 0.766): A modified multilateral framework — China-Oman-Pakistan as primary brokers, with Russia in a supporting role and Turkey as secondary channel — will facilitate negotiations. Direct US-Iran talks will begin indirectly, transitioning to semi-direct engagement by 2027. Iran will deny "negotiations" publicly while conducting them privately — this is consistent with every diplomatic episode in US-Iran history. The April 2026 dynamic (Trump claiming talks "going very well," Iran denying) is itself the opening move in this familiar pattern.

Israel's Role (SCAT-02-03, composite 0.715): Israel will not participate formally in negotiations and will not be required to. The US has historically concluded Iran-related agreements over Israeli objections when US interests are served — JCPOA being the clearest example. Netanyahu's coalition will publicly oppose any deal that doesn't include full Iranian nuclear dismantlement, but will privately accept a "verified cap plus monitoring" outcome if US provides supplementary security guarantees (additional Iron Dome batteries, accelerated F-35 deliveries, joint targeting commitments). US pressure on Israel to refrain from unilateral strikes during negotiations is the critical diplomatic task.

Regional Legitimization (SCAT-02-04, composite 0.729): KSA's participation is essential to legitimizing any settlement. Riyadh will not "endorse" a deal that appears to reward Iran for aggression, but will issue carefully worded statements supporting "regional stability" and "dialogue" that function as implicit endorsements. The Arab League framework will similarly provide cover language. KSA's primary deliverable is Houthi de-escalation in Yemen and Iranian non-interference in Bahrain — securing these bilateral gains is the price KSA will extract for regional legitimization support.

Critical Gap: The diplomatic process faces a structural challenge: Iran does not trust that any US agreement will survive a change in administration. The solution — making China the economic guarantor — partially addresses this, as Chinese

economic investment in Iran's compliance creates a durable enforcement mechanism independent of US domestic politics. This is the architectural innovation that JCPOA-2 must include to achieve durability.

CAT-03: Economic & Sanctions Framework

Category Prediction Confidence: HIGH (0.74)

Economics is simultaneously Iran's greatest vulnerability and its primary incentive for a deal. Sanctions + war damage + Strait closure have created an acute economic crisis. The economic dimension of any peace framework is also the most tractable — unlike nuclear verification or security guarantees, financial flows are measurable, reversible, and immediately impactful.

Strait of Hormuz (SCAT-03-02, composite 0.792 — highest scored hypothesis in analysis): This is the most strategically certain element of any settlement pathway. Iran will reopen the Strait because it must — the closure damages Iran's own future economic recovery, antagonizes China (its primary economic patron), and provides no durable military advantage. China's pressure on Tehran to reopen the Strait, in exchange for economic guarantees and reconstruction financing commitments, is the single most powerful lever available. The Strait's partial reopening (for non-US-flagged shipping) will likely be the first concrete deliverable of any ceasefire framework — a confidence-building measure that demonstrates Iran's good faith without full capitulation.

Sanctions Sequencing (SCAT-03-01, composite 0.765): The sequencing debate — who moves first? — will be the central sticking point in economic negotiations. Iran's position (shaped by the JCPOA experience, where Trump's 2018 withdrawal eliminated all sanctions relief gains) is that sanctions relief must be front-loaded and legally binding before nuclear compliance. The US position is the inverse: compliance first, then relief. The resolution — as in JCPOA — will be phased: an initial tranche of frozen assets (~$20–30B) released upon ceasefire + IAEA re-engagement; subsequent tranches tied to verified nuclear compliance milestones over 36 months. The "snap-back" mechanism will be stronger than JCPOA's (automatic, without UNSC vote) to provide US leverage without requiring Congressional action.

Oil Market Re-integration (SCAT-03-03, composite 0.736): Iran's return to global oil markets at 2–3 million bpd (from a pre-war peak of ~3.8 mbpd) is achievable

within 18 months of a deal. China and India are the primary buyers; KSA will negotiate informal OPEC+ accommodations. The key variable is KSA's willingness to accept reduced market share — and given that KSA desperately needs Gulf stability to secure its Vision 2030 investments, the trade-off is acceptable. Iran's oil infrastructure damage (if any — strikes primarily targeted nuclear and military facilities) would be repaired through Chinese investment under the 25-year partnership.

Reconstruction (SCAT-03-04, composite 0.706): China will provide the primary reconstruction financing under the 25-year strategic partnership framework ($400B commitment). Western institutional financing (IMF, World Bank) remains unavailable until full sanctions relief — which creates a structural dependency on Chinese financing that Beijing will leverage for economic and political influence. A UN-administered multilateral reconstruction fund is a credible alternative that GCC states could co-finance, but requires UNSC consensus that China and Russia will condition on other diplomatic concessions.

CAT-04: Regional Stakeholder Positions

Category Prediction Confidence: HIGH (0.74)

The regional stakeholders — KSA, China, Russia, Turkey — are not peripheral to this conflict; they are structural components of any durable peace architecture. No settlement survives without KSA's acquiescence and China's economic guarantorship.

China (SCAT-04-02, composite 0.806 — joint highest score in analysis): China is the indispensable actor. Its structural position — economic patron of Iran, primary oil buyer from the Gulf, 2023 KSA-Iran broker — gives it leverage that no other actor possesses. China has every incentive to broker this deal: Strait closure threatens Chinese energy security; Iranian instability threatens the Belt and Road corridor; and a China-brokered settlement demonstrates Beijing's capacity for global leadership in a domain previously dominated by the US. China's peace plan (debuted April 1, 2026) is the starting framework for multilateral negotiations, and China will insist on being the primary interlocutor — which both Iran and the Gulf states are more willing to accept than US leadership on this issue.

Saudi Arabia/GCC (SCAT-04-01, composite 0.772): KSA's position has been consistent: it will not participate in military operations against Iran, it will not

normalize relations with Israel without Palestinian state progress, and it will support any regional stability framework that: (a) reopens the Strait, (b) ends Houthi operations in Yemen, and (c) provides KSA-specific non-interference guarantees. MBS has demonstrated (via the 2023 China-brokered KSA-Iran rapprochement) that he is willing to make pragmatic deals with adversaries when the economic and security calculus aligns. KSA will extract bilateral concessions from Iran as the price of regional endorsement — this is achievable given Iran's weakened position.

Russia (SCAT-04-03, composite 0.706): Russia is a supporting player, not a lead mediator. Its value is UNSC veto restraint and its direct communication channel with Tehran (Russia-Iran 20-year partnership). Russia will support the settlement framework in exchange for implicit gains on separate issues (Ukraine sanctions relief, Western diplomatic recognition of Russian interests). The Kremlin's pattern — calling Gulf state leaders, positioning itself as "in constant contact" with Iran — is consistent with a mediation-for-influence strategy rather than genuine peace-making. Russia's support is a necessary condition for UNSC endorsement but not sufficient for deal-making.

Turkey (SCAT-04-04, composite 0.665 — MODERATE): Turkey plays a secondary but useful role. Its 2010 Tehran Declaration precedent, NATO membership, and Muslim-majority credibility make it a credible secondary channel. Turkey will host informal consultations and serve as a message relay between NATO and Iran. However, Turkey's own regional ambitions (Kurdish issue, Syria) and Erdogan's habit of transactional diplomacy limit its reliability as a genuine broker.

CAT-05: Iranian Domestic Political Dynamics

Category Prediction Confidence: MODERATE (0.66)

This is the most uncertain category — the domestic black box that determines whether any external deal framework is ratifiable and sustainable within Iran. The assassination of Ali Khamenei, the rapid election of his son Mojtaba (March 8, 2026), and the degradation of IRGC military capacity have created a genuinely unprecedented political configuration in the Islamic Republic.

Mojtaba Khamenei's Direction (SCAT-05-01, composite 0.738): The most likely interpretation of Mojtaba Khamenei's behavior is "resistant pragmatism" — a

pattern established by his father after Iran-Iraq War (1988 ceasefire: “drinking the cup of poison”) and by Rouhani during the JCPOA period. The new Supreme Leader inherits a severely weakened state, a legitimacy deficit (he has no independent religious or political track record), and an IRGC that is its own power center. He must satisfy the IRGC to survive, but he also understands that economic collapse threatens the entire Islamic Republic system. The resolution: hardline rhetoric externally, pragmatic deal-making via proxies internally.

IRGC Compliance (SCAT-05-02, composites 0.638–0.692): The IRGC’s position is the most consequential domestic variable. Several IRGC commanders were killed in the strikes. The surviving institutional leadership has seen its military capacity degraded and its proxy network dismantled or weakened. The IRGC’s calculus will be: (a) institutional survival within the Islamic Republic system > (b) nuclear program preservation > (c) proxy network preservation. A deal that preserves IRGC’s domestic economic empire and avoids formal prosecution is acceptable. The IRGC will maintain covert nuclear knowledge while accepting formal verification — a “dual track” of compliance and hedge.

Public Opinion (SCAT-05-03, composite 0.752): The Iranian public’s initial rally-round-flag response to the war (particularly the outrage at Khamenei’s assassination by a foreign power) will sustain hardliner narratives for 6–12 months. However, Iran’s pre-war economic condition was already severe (40%+ inflation, currency collapse, youth unemployment), and the war’s economic damage will compound this rapidly. By Q4 2026, public pressure for economic recovery will become a significant driver for regime flexibility. The Iranian public has shown (in multiple protest cycles since 2009) that it can generate political pressure on the regime — and economic survival is the trigger that most consistently translates into actionable pressure.

Reformist/Technocrat Influence (SCAT-05-04, composite 0.695): President Ghalibaf’s role is critical — he set Iran’s public terms for peace (March 12, 2026) and has been the face of pragmatic negotiation. The Ghalibaf-led technocratic faction, aligned with the “economic survival” imperative, will be the internal engine of deal-making. Whether hardliners can veto this process depends on Mojtaba Khamenei’s direction: if the new Supreme Leader provides political cover to Ghalibaf, the pragmatists succeed; if hardliners weaponize the Supreme Leader’s legitimacy crisis against the deal, the timeline extends significantly.

—— CONFIDENCE DASHBOARD ——

Category	Avg Composite Score	Confidence Band
CAT-01: Nuclear & Security Architecture	0.70	HIGH
CAT-02: Diplomatic Process	0.73	HIGH
CAT-03: Economic & Sanctions Framework	0.74	HIGH
CAT-04: Regional Stakeholder Positions	0.74	HIGH
CAT-05: Iranian Domestic Dynamics	0.66	MODERATE
Overall Composite	**0.71**	**HIGH-MODERATE**

Subcategory Confidence Rankings (Top 10)

Rank	S.Cat	Composite	Band
1	SCAT-03-02: Strait of Hormuz Re-opening	0.792	HIGH
2	SCAT-04-02: China's Mediation Role	0.806	HIGH
3	SCAT-02-02: Multilateral Framework	0.766	HIGH
4	SCAT-03-01: Sanctions Relief Sequencing	0.765	HIGH
5	SCAT-02-01: Bilateral US-Iran Talks	0.752	HIGH
6	SCAT-05-03: Iranian Public Opinion Dynamics	0.752	HIGH
7	SCAT-04-01: KSA/GCC Strategic Calculus	0.772	HIGH
8	SCAT-03-03: Oil Market Re-integration	0.736	HIGH
9	SCAT-05-01: New Supreme Leader Direction	0.738	HIGH
10	SCAT-01-01: Iran Nuclear Program Caps	0.738	HIGH

—— KEY UNCERTAINTIES ——

1. **Mojtaba Khamenei's ideological trajectory** — Will the new Supreme Leader pursue pragmatic survival or hardline legitimacy-building? This single variable could shift the timeline by 18–24 months.
2. **IRGC institutional coherence post-war** — Are IRGC hardliners capable of vetoing a deal, or has military degradation shifted the balance toward civilian pragmatists? The answer is unknown until tested.
3. **US Congressional sanctions architecture** — Can the Trump administration deliver sanctions relief without legislative approval? Executive-order-based sanctions relief is reversible by the next administration — Iran knows this, creating a structural credibility deficit that China's economic guarantorship only partially offsets.
4. **Israeli unilateral action risk (~12%)** — Netanyahu's coalition is politically dependent on preventing any outcome that appears to reward Iran's survival. An Israeli unilateral strike during negotiations remains the most consequential tail risk.
5. **China-US geopolitical competition spillover** — If US-China tensions escalate in another theater (Taiwan, South China Sea) during the negotiation period, China's mediator role becomes politically untenable for the US, potentially collapsing the framework.

—— KEY PLAYERS: POSITIONS, INTERESTS & LEVERAGE ——

🇮🇷 IRAN (Post-Khamenei)

Current Position: Active belligerent; Strait of Hormuz partially closed; denying talks with US
Core Interests: Regime survival, IRGC institutional preservation, sovereignty recognition, economic recovery
Minimum Conditions for Deal: Sanctions relief + credible non-aggression guarantee + no formal nuclear dismantlement
Leverage: Strait of Hormuz control; residual nuclear knowledge; Chinese/Russian backing; proxy network residual capacity

Key Actor: President Ghalibaf (pragmatic deal-maker); Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei (institutional legitimacy gatekeeper)

🇺🇸 USA (Trump Administration)

Current Position: Active belligerent; claiming “great progress” in talks; April 6 deadline on power plant strikes
Core Interests: Nuclear non-proliferation, Strait re-opening, claiming “win” domestically
Minimum Conditions for Deal: Verifiable nuclear cap (enrichment limits + IAEA access); cessation of Iran-backed attacks on US assets
Leverage: Military dominance; sanctions control; Gulf alliance network; ability to resume strikes
Key Actor: Trump (deal-maker framing, but constrained by MAGA hawks); envoys via Pakistan channel
Constraint: US Congress hawkish on Iran; deal cannot look like “appeasement”

🇮🇱 ISRAEL

Current Position: Active belligerent; ongoing strikes (late March: struck uranium facility in Yazd)
Core Interests: Permanent elimination of Iranian nuclear threat; preservation of regional military superiority
Minimum Conditions for Deal: Verifiable nuclear non-weaponization; IAEA anytime/anywhere access; termination of IRGC proxy aggression against Israel
Leverage: Military strike capacity; US alliance; intelligence dominance (demonstrated by killing scientists/commanders)
Key Actor: Netanyahu (politically dependent on hawkish coalition); Israeli military/intelligence establishment
Constraint: Israeli public and military hawkish; accepting any deal requires “victory” framing

🇸🇦 SAUDI ARABIA (KSA/GCC)

Current Position: Refused territory for operations against Iran; seeking bilateral gains; enabling Strait re-opening pressure
Core Interests: Regional stability for Vision 2030; Strait open for oil exports; Iranian non-interference in Gulf domestic affairs; Palestinian issue for domestic

legitimacy
Minimum Conditions for Deal: Iranian non-interference guarantee in Bahrain and Yemen; Houthi de-escalation; partial Strait re-opening
Leverage: Oil market management; US security partnership; China's Gulf energy dependency; Arab League leadership
Key Actor: MBS (proven pragmatist; brokered Iran rapprochement in 2023 via China)

🇨🇳 CHINA

Current Position: Condemned strikes; debuted peace plan (April 1); positioning as "honest broker"
Core Interests: Energy security (Gulf oil); Iran economic partnership; demonstrating global governance leadership; preventing US dominance of regional order
Leverage: Economic patron of Iran ($400B 25-year partnership); Gulf's primary oil buyer (can pressure KSA); established KSA-Iran broker credibility (2023)
Constraint: Unwilling to provide military guarantees that risk direct US confrontation; "conditional partnerships"
Key Actor: Xi Jinping and Foreign Minister Wang Yi (directly leading Iran peace diplomacy)

🇷🇺 RUSSIA

Current Position: Verbally condemned strikes; positioning as secondary mediator; "constant contact" with Gulf states
Core Interests: Demonstrate diplomatic relevance; normalize Russia post-Ukraine; extract US concessions on Ukraine as part of Iran package
Leverage: UNSC veto; Russia-Iran 20-year partnership; arms supply relationship; OPEC+ membership
Constraint: Ukraine war entanglement limits bandwidth and credibility; own sanctions constrain economic leverage
Key Actor: Putin and Lavrov (both publicly committed to mediator role)

—— RECOMMENDED PEACE ARCHITECTURE: THE "TEHRAN GRAND BARGAIN" ——

Based on the full MDQ analysis, the most viable lasting peace framework contains these non-negotiable structural elements:

1. Nuclear Settlement — "Verified Threshold Status"
- Iran's enrichment capped at 20% purity; no enrichment to 90%+
- IAEA monitoring with enhanced "Additional Protocol" inspection rights
- Iran rejoins NPT framework (NPT exit vote rescinded as part of deal)
- 440kg of 60%-enriched uranium transferred to a third-party custodian (China)
- Timeline: Iran gets 36 months to come into full compliance; sanctions relief staged accordingly

2. Security Architecture — "Multilateral Non-Aggression Framework"
- US executive declaration of non-aggression (not Senate-ratified treaty)
- China and Russia serve as formal co-signatories and economic guarantors
- Oman/Qatar permanent monitoring role for compliance disputes
- IRGC receives implicit (not formal) institutional survival guarantee
- No formal prosecution of IRGC leaders for war crimes as part of deal

3. Economic Reintegration — "Phased Sanctions Relief with Chinese Guarantee"
- $25B in frozen assets released immediately upon ceasefire + IAEA re-engagement
- Additional $30–50B in staged relief tied to nuclear compliance milestones
- Iran's oil exports resume to China and India at 2–3 mbpd within 18 months
- Strait of Hormuz fully reopened within 6 months of ceasefire
- China provides reconstruction financing; UN multilateral fund established for additional international contributions

4. Regional Architecture — "KSA-Iran Bilateral Stabilization Compact"
- Iran formally commits to non-interference in Bahrain, Yemen (Houthi de-escalation), and Kuwait
- KSA provides regional endorsement of peace framework; maintains China-mediated communication channel with Iran
- Saudi-Israel normalization removed from immediate agenda but roadmap reestablished contingent on Palestinian process progress
- GCC security framework enhanced with US commitment (not directed at Iran)

5. Proxy Network Management — "Controlled Wind-Down Protocol"
- Iran formally commits to no expansion of IRGC proxy networks

- Hezbollah activities in Lebanon subject to UNIFIL-enhanced monitoring
- Houthi operations in Yemen subject to UN-verified ceasefire
- Iran does not formally dismantle proxies (not achievable and not durable if forced); instead commits to no new proxy formation and no escalation of existing ones

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—— PHASE 3 EVIDENCE INDEX ——

Source	Category	Stance	Recency
Arms Control Association Analysis, March–April 2026	Nuclear negotiations	Supporting	1.0×
Wikipedia: 2025–2026 Iran-US Negotiations	Diplomatic history	Neutral	1.0×
Al Jazeera: Iran ceasefire terms (March 12, 2026)	Iran position	Neutral	1.0×
CNBC: Trump Iran ceasefire claim (April 1, 2026)	US position	Neutral	1.0×
Britannica: 2026 Iran War	Conflict background	Neutral	1.0×
RAND: War in Iran Q&A (March 2026)	Strategic analysis	Neutral	1.0×
Washington Institute: Great Power Spillover (2026)	Regional dynamics	Neutral	1.0×
ACLED: Middle East Special Issue (March 2026)	Conflict data	Supporting	1.0×
CFR Global Conflict Tracker: Iran-Israel	Historical context	Neutral	0.8×
Eurasia Review: 2025-2026 US-Israel-Iran War Analysis	Geopolitics	Neutral	1.0×
Atlantic Council: Saudi-Israeli Normalization Analysis	KSA position	Neutral	0.8×
CSIS: Iran War Strategy Analysis	Military strategy	Neutral	1.0×
ME Council: Saudi-Iranian Détente	KSA-Iran relations	Supporting	0.8×

Source	Category	Stance	Recency
FDD: Strikes on Iranian Nuclear Sites (March 2026)	Nuclear damage	Neutral	1.0×
Breitbart/China peace plan (April 1, 2026)	China mediation	Neutral	1.0×
War on the Rocks: Limits of Force Against Iran (Feb 2026)	Nuclear analysis	Neutral	1.0×

No single source exceeds 30% of total evidence base. Source diversity: academic/think tank (7), news/analysis (6), government/multilateral (3).

—— METADATA ——

Field	Value
Scenario ID	iran-us-israel-peace-2026
Analysis Date	2026-04-03
Phase 1 CS ID	cs-2026-04-03-001
MECE Tree ID	tree-2026-04-03-001
Total SH Nodes	48 (16 subcategories × 3 types)
Consideration Set	35 HIGH + MODERATE SH
Archived (LOW)	13 tail_risk SH
MECE Violations	0
Source Diversity	16 unique sources across 6 source types
Max Single Source Weight	~8% (well below 30% cap)
Overall Pipeline Confidence	HIGH-MODERATE (composite 0.71)
Temporal Horizon	2026–2030 (4-year window)
Model Used	Sonnet 4.6 (full pipeline)

MDQ Predictive Intelligence System | Phase 1→2→3→4 Complete PipelineAnalysis: tabish.pro.geek@gmail.com | Generated: 2026-04-03